

1850



A depiction of one of the many bloody battles during the Taiping Rebellion.

IN THE SAME WAY CHINA HAD

TRIED TO KEEP European ships from its ports, it had also tried to drive out Christian missionaries, thereby limiting the influence of **Christianity**. Despite this, by the mid-19th century some 200,000 Chinese had been **converted**, and thousands more were familiar with the religion.

In 1850, officials sent troops to disband a religious society whose beliefs were loosely based on **Protestant** ideas. This sect was led by **Hong Xiuquan** (1814–64) who, believing himself to be the younger brother of Jesus Christ, launched a revolt that became the **Taiping Rebellion**. Drawn by his call to share property, many starving peasants joined the ranks and fighting went on for 14 years, claiming millions of lives.

20 MILLION
THE NUMBER OF PEOPLE
KILLED OVER
THE COURSE
OF THE
TAIPING REBELLION

1851



A hand-colored lithograph shows the Crystal Palace at the Great Exhibition of 1851 in London's Hyde Park. Some six million people visited it in six months.

“IT IS A WONDERFUL PLACE—**VAST, STRANGE, NEW, AND IMPOSSIBLE TO DESCRIBE.**”

Charlotte Brontë, English novelist, on visiting the Great Exhibition

IN LONDON, THE WORLD WAS ON DISPLAY. An exhibition had been organized, billed as the “Great Exhibition of the Works of Industry of all Nations.” The **Great Exhibition**, as it became known, was housed in the Crystal Palace, an exhibition hall made of glass and iron built for the occasion. Some six million people pored over the 100,000 exhibitions between May 1 and October 31. Of the 14,000 participating exhibitors, almost half were from overseas. An enormous variety of agricultural and manufactured items were on display, ranging from the **Koh-i-Noor diamond** from India to tapestries from Persia, and British engineering equipment.

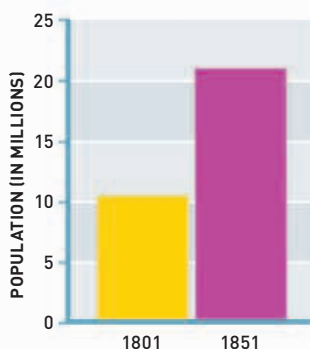
In the same year as this global event, a **telegraph cable** was laid across the English Channel, facilitating rapid international communication.

Britain by this point had seen a large **population** boom and become more **urbanized** as agricultural workers moved to the cities to work in the growing number of factories (see 1771). Detailed censuses showed that the population of London had

surged from about one million in 1801 to over two million by 1851.

In **Australia**, the discovery of gold in Victoria and New South Wales the same year prompted a **gold rush** that tripled the country's population over the next ten years.

In Siam (Thailand), **King Mongkut** (1804–68) began his rule. His reign saw increased relations with the West. During this period, he employed an English governess, **Anna Leonowens** (1831–1915), whose memoirs inspired the 20th-century musical *The King and I*.



Rise in Britain's population
The population of England, Scotland, and Wales nearly doubled in fifty years, from 10.6 million in 1801 to almost 21 million by 1851.

1852



The Royal Navy played a significant role in the Anglo-Burmese War.

HOSTILITIES HAD ONCE AGAIN

flared up between British troops and the Burmese. After making extensive territorial gains in the last war against **Burma** (see 1823), Britain was eager to control more of the area. Wider control would create an overland coastal connection from Calcutta in Britain's Indian territory to the British port in Singapore. The East India Company also wanted access to the **teak forests** in Burma. In 1852, the British seized a ship belonging to Burma's king, and this was enough to start the **Second Anglo-Burmese War**. Lasting only a few months, British troops were able to take southern territory, ousting the reigning king, Pagan Min (1811–80), and installing his brother, Mindon Min (1814–78), who was willing to accept British control of the southern portion of the kingdom.

In **West Africa**, in present-day Senegal, Muslim Tukulor chief **Umar Tall** (1797–1864) capitalized on unrest between the Dingiraye and Bambara people to wage a jihad (holy war) on part of upper **Senegal**, taking control of the territory. His empire would eventually stretch to **Timbuktu** in present-day Mali. His rule was a time of further entrenchment of Islam in West Africa.

In South Africa, the British acknowledged the independence of the **Transvaal** after refusing to accept the previous Boer Republic of Natal (see 1843). This was followed two years later with a similar acceptance of the settlers' new **Orange Free State**.

1853



Commodore Matthew Perry brought Japan a railroad car as a gift.

US COMMODORE MATTHEW PERRY

(1794–1858) had been charged with opening up trade between the US and the secluded **Japan**. Japan had been under international pressure to open up its ports to foreign merchants for years. The Dutch, who were the only Europeans allowed very limited **access to trade** in Japan, sent a mission in 1844 urging the country's rulers to allow in more ships. This was followed by French and British requests for trading rights. A delegation from the US was sent away empty-handed (see 1846). However, the US government was eager to secure trading rights in East Asia and so sent Perry to further negotiate. He arrived on July 8 and refused to leave until he had delivered his letters. The Japanese relented after a few days and took his papers, which requested a trade treaty. They eventually consented to the terms, and the **Treaty of Kanagawa** was concluded the following year.

As **China** was contending with the Taiping Rebellion (see 1850), another uprising broke out in the central and eastern provinces. The rebels were composed of many outlaws, as well as peasants from famine-stricken areas. With the government otherwise engaged, the rebels were able to form armies and begin the **Nien Rebellion**. Over the course of the next 15 years they gained control of much of northern China, although they were eventually defeated.

December 16 First settlers for Christchurch arrive in New Zealand

April 1 Rama IV (1804–68) takes the Thai throne

May–October Great Exhibition of Industry takes place in Crystal Palace in Hyde Park, London

September 30 Eugénies begins voyage from Sweden; Royal Navy vessel to circumnavigate world

October A telegraph cable is successfully installed across the English Channel

Second Anglo-Burmese War (to 1853) begins

Independent Boer republic of Transvaal in South Africa recognized by Britain

Louis-Napoléon becomes Emperor

Napoleon III

American writer Harriet Beecher Stowe (1811–96) publishes abolitionist novel Uncle Tom's Cabin

March 20 Taiping Rebellion: Rebel army takes Nanjing, killing 30,000 Imperial troops

March 30 Dutch painter Vincent Van Gogh born (d. 1890)

October 4 Crimean War (to 1856) begins over disputed territory within Ottoman Empire

October 12 New Zealand becomes independent